



Understanding Readability Measures

A Guide for Sesotho Teachers

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Preamble

This handbook supports a series of training sessions with Sesotho language teachers, focusing on the understanding and evaluation of traditional readability measures. These sessions are part of a broader process to reflect on and test the readability tools I developed during my doctoral research in 2023.

The aim is to make sure that teachers are equipped with the knowledge and confidence to:

- Understand what readability is,
- Apply traditional readability measures to Sesotho texts,
- Critically reflect on their usefulness in the classroom,
- And offer feedback to improve or localise these tools for practical teaching purposes.

This is a working document. It is not set in stone — your experience, insight, and classroom knowledge are vital. Your feedback is not only welcome, it is essential.

Selelekela

Bukana ena e tshehetsa letoto la dithupelo le matitjhere a puo ya Sesotho, e tobane le kutlwisiso le tekolo ya mekhwa ya kgale ya ho bala. Dikopano tsena ke karolo ea tshebetso e pharalletseng ya ho nahanisisa le ho lekola disebeliswa tsa ho bala tseo ke di entseng nakong ya dipatlisiso tsa ka tsa bongaka ka 2023.

Sepheo ke ho etsa bonnete ba hore matitjhere a hlomellwa ka tsebo le kgodiseho ya ho:

- Utlwisisa hore na ho bala ke eng,
- Sebedisa mekhwa ya kgale ya ho bala dingodilweng tsa Sesotho,
- Nahana ka botebo ka bohlokwa ba tsona ka phaposing ya borutelo,
- Le ho fana ka maikutlo a ho ntlafatsa kapa ho fetolela disebediswa tsena molemong wa ho ruta.

Ena ke tokomane e sebetsang. Ha ya thehwa lelweng - boiphihlelo ba hao, temohisiso le tsebo ya phaposi ya hao di bohlokwa. Maikutlo a hao ha a amohelehe feela, empa a bohlokwa.

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Chapter 1

What is Readability, and Why it Matters!

What is Readability?

Traditional readability measures are formulas and tools designed to estimate how easy or difficult a text is to read. They are usually based on:

- Sentence length (average number of words per sentence),
- Word length or complexity (e.g. syllables per word or use of familiar vs unfamiliar words),
- And sometimes vocabulary frequency (how often words appear in everyday language).

While these were originally designed for English, part of this project is to explore how these types of measures can be adapted and applied to Sesotho texts, and what their limitations might be in African language contexts.

Why is Readability Important for Teachers?

As teachers, especially in African language contexts like Sesotho, we often work with learners who have varying reading abilities. Ensuring that our learning materials are readable helps learners:

- Build confidence.
- Understand instructions and tasks better.
- Engage more meaningfully with the content.
- Develop stronger literacy skills.

When a text is too difficult:

- Learners struggle with comprehension.
- Learning becomes frustrating.
- They may disengage from reading altogether

Readability affects:

- Learner comprehension – If texts are too difficult, learners may disengage.
- Curriculum alignment – Ensuring texts match grade-level expectations.
- Textbook evaluation – Making informed choices about learning materials.
- Inclusive learning – Supporting all learners, especially in multilingual and resource-constrained classrooms.

In the Sesotho classroom, this matters deeply because:

- Teachers often rely on materials that have not been tested for readability.
- Learners are navigating language complexity in a rapidly changing educational environment.
- There is a growing need for **evidence-based** approaches in text selection.

Readability and Language Development

In African language classrooms, the issue of readability is even more important because:

- Learners may be learning to read in their home language for the first time.
- There may be limited access to high-quality texts written in Sesotho.
- Translation of English texts into Sesotho often affects sentence structure and word choice, making the text more difficult.

A clear understanding of readability helps teachers:

- Select appropriate materials for learners' reading levels.
- Adapt texts when needed.
- Support the development of reading fluency and comprehension.

Key Concepts to Understand

Term	Meaning	Example
Readability	How easy a text is to read and understand	A Grade 4 learner can easily read a story with short, common words
Comprehension	How well a learner understands what they read	A learner can explain the events in the story after reading
Cognitive load	The amount of mental effort needed to understand the text	A text with many difficult words increases cognitive load
Reader level	The reading ability of the learner	A Grade 6 learner might still read at a Grade 4 level
Text complexity	The features of the text that make it easier or harder to read	Long sentences and rare words increase complexity

Myths and Misconceptions About Traditional Readability Measures

Understanding readability requires separating facts from myths. Here are some common misconceptions:

Myth 1: "If a text is short, it is easy to read."

Reality: Short texts can still use complex vocabulary or unfamiliar concepts. Sentence and word length are just part of the picture.

Myth 2: "Traditional readability formulas are perfect and universal."

Reality: Most traditional formulas were designed for English texts. They need to be adapted carefully to suit languages like Sesotho, which have different grammatical and morphological features.

Myth 3: "Teachers don't need readability tools — they can judge by experience."

Reality: Teacher experience is essential, but tools can support and strengthen professional judgement, especially when selecting texts for diverse learners.

Myth 4: "Readability only matters in early grades."

Reality: Readability affects comprehension at all levels, including high school and adult literacy. Text difficulty should match learners' developmental and cognitive stages.

Myth 5: "Readability measures tell you everything about a text."

Reality: They only tell part of the story. Context, learner background, prior knowledge, and text purpose are equally important.

Reflective Activity

Think about the following questions:

- Have you ever used a text that learners struggled to read? What happened?
- Do you think learners in your class are always given texts that suit their reading level?
- How do you usually choose the texts you use for teaching?

Think-Pair-Share:

1. Think of two texts you have used recently.
2. Which one was more readable for your learners? Why?

Share with a partner and discuss what made one text easier than the other.



Chapter 2

The Role of Readability in the Classroom

Choosing Appropriate Texts for Different Grades

One of the most practical uses of readability measures is helping teachers select texts that are developmentally appropriate for their learners. In the Sesotho classroom, this is particularly important as learners progress from basic language acquisition to more complex comprehension and critical thinking.

Traditional readability measures can guide:

- Foundation Phase teachers to select simple, repetitive texts with high-frequency vocabulary.
- Intermediate Phase teachers to introduce more complex sentence structures and richer vocabulary.
- Senior Phase and FET teachers to use texts with abstract concepts and academic language, while still being mindful of linguistic accessibility.

Tip for Teachers: Always pair readability scores with your knowledge of learners' language proficiency and interests.

Supporting Comprehension Through Readable Texts

Readability directly affects how well learners understand what they read. When learners are given texts that are too difficult, they are more likely to:

- Lose interest,
- Struggle with decoding and vocabulary,
- Miss out on deeper meaning and critical engagement.

Readable texts:

- Enable scaffolded learning (building up from what learners already know),
- Promote confidence and fluency,
- Enhance learners' ability to make inferences, summarise, and reflect.

Note: Even culturally relevant texts may need to be assessed for readability to ensure they support comprehension.

Readability and Learner Motivation

A good match between the learner's reading level and text difficulty encourages:

- A sense of achievement,
- Enjoyment of reading,
- Greater participation in classroom discussions.

On the other hand, if the text is too easy, learners may become bored. If it is too hard, they may feel discouraged. Finding that "just right" level is key to keeping learners engaged and motivated to read more.

Reflection Point: Have you noticed learners disengaging from certain texts? Do you think it may have been because they are struggling to read the text?

Case Examples in Sesotho Education



Case 1: Grade 4 Learners and Folktales

A Grade 4 teacher introduced traditional Sesotho folktales into her reading curriculum. However, learners struggled with long compound sentences and unfamiliar proverbs. After analysing the texts using traditional readability formulas, she adapted the stories to include:

- Shorter sentences,
- Simpler vocabulary,
- Glossaries for idiomatic expressions.

Result: Improved comprehension and more active participation.



Case 2: FET Phase Literature Class

An FET teacher used a Sesotho novel that had been prescribed for Grade 12. While linguistically rich, the text's sentence length and low-frequency vocabulary caused comprehension barriers. By chunking the text into smaller sections and supporting it with guided reading strategies, the teacher aligned instruction with learners' reading levels.

Result: Increased confidence in dealing with complex texts, better exam responses.



Case 3: Home Language vs First Additional Language Learners

In a mixed classroom, some learners spoke Sesotho as a home language, while others learned it as a First Additional Language. Readability analysis helped the teacher:

- Differentiate texts,
- Provide simplified reading materials for beginners,
- Use the original texts for advanced readers.

Result: Personalised support and improved reading outcomes across the classroom.

Final Thoughts

Readability is not a one-size-fits-all solution, but it is a powerful tool when used thoughtfully. By considering readability when selecting, adapting, and teaching texts, Sesotho teachers can play a crucial role in fostering comprehension, engagement, and a lifelong love of reading.

Next Step: In the next chapter, we will explore how to apply readability formulas to Sesotho texts and interpret the results for practical classroom use.

Chapter 3: Readability Formulas and Tools

Traditional readability measures—such as grade-level formulas—produce numerical scores or grade-level estimates. These measures assess readability by estimating the level of education typically required to read a text with ease. However, they tend to provide generalised assessments aimed at broad user groups, rather than being tailored to the abilities or characteristics of individual readers. As a result, personal reading factors beyond educational attainment are often overlooked.

To evaluate the readability of the Sesotho texts, nine widely used readability measures were adapted from English to Sesotho: Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level, Flesch Reading Ease, Simple Measure of Gobbledygook, Gunning Fog Index, Lasbarhets index, Readability index, Automatic Readability Index, Coleman-Liau Index, and Dale-Chall Index.

The following section provides a brief summary of each measure used in this analysis.

Syllable-based measures

Four of the readability measures selected rely on syllable-based information. These are outlined below.

Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level (FKGL)

The Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level (FKGL) estimates readability using U.S. school grade levels. For instance, a score of 10 indicates that a text is suitable for a tenth-grade reader. The formula used to calculate FKGL is:

$$FKGL_{Sesotho} = -14.08905 + 0.43405\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 5.86314\left(\frac{\#syllables}{\#words}\right)$$

The FKGL looks at two things. One, it checks the average number of syllables in each word. More syllables usually mean harder words. Two, it also looks at how many words are in each sentence. Longer sentences can be more difficult to read.

The calculation involves four steps. First, the average sentence length is determined by dividing the number of words by the number of sentences, then multiplying the result by 0.43405. Second, the average syllables per word are calculated by dividing the number of syllables by the number of words and multiplying by 5.86314. Third, the two results are added together. Lastly, 14.08905 is subtracted to produce the final readability score.

Flesch Reading Ease (FRE)

The Flesch Reading Ease (FRE) is among the most widely used traditional readability formulas. It has been extensively adapted to various languages, including French, Italian, Russian, Dutch, Bangla, and Czech. In the Southern African context, the formula has also

been adapted for Afrikaans, with several variations developed to suit the language's specific linguistic features. It has now been adapted to Sesotho with the following formula:

$$FRE_{Sesotho} = 209.3286 - 1.7930\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) - 46.6548\left(\frac{\#syllables}{\#words}\right)$$

The FRE formula assesses readability based on sentence length and syllable count, producing a score typically ranging from 0 to 100. Higher scores indicate easier readability, while lower scores suggest more complex texts. The FRE is often used in combination with the FKGL formula to evaluate both first- and second-language texts. The original English one did not work on Sesotho (see Sibeko 2024).

Gunning Fog Index (GFI)

The Gunning Fog Index (GFI) assesses readability by identifying complex words—defined as words containing more than two syllables. The index is calculated through a four-step process. First, the average number of words per sentence is determined. Second, the total number of complex words in the text is counted. Third, the percentage of complex words is computed. Finally, the average sentence length and the percentage of complex words are added together and multiplied by a constant factor of 0.4. The formula for GFI is expressed as:

$$GFI(1)_{Sesotho} = -4.30942 + 0.28610\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + \left(\frac{\#complex-words}{\#words}\right)$$

$$GFI(2)_{Sesotho} = -1.77916 + 0.40861\left(\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 30.9982\left(\frac{\#complex-words}{\#words}\right)\right)$$

Scores typically range from six to twenty, where lower values indicate easier readability. For instance, a score of six corresponds to a sixth-grade reading level, while scores closer to twenty suggest that the text is suitable for highly advanced readers.

Simple Measure of Gobbledygook (SMOG)

The Simple Measure of Gobbledygook (SMOG) estimates readability by focusing on polysyllabic words—those with more than two syllables—and the structure of sentences. In Sibeko and van Zaanen (2024), we propose the following formula for Sesotho:

$$SMOG_{Sesotho} = 0.28788 + 0.68741\left(\sqrt{\#polysyllabic - words * \left(\frac{30}{\#sentences}\right)}\right)$$

Like the GFI, SMOG outputs scores aligned with United States school grade levels, where higher scores reflect increased reading difficulty. It is particularly valued for its straightforward approach to identifying linguistic complexity in texts aimed at general

audiences. The formula assumes that the presence of more polysyllabic words indicates greater cognitive effort required for comprehension. We still need to evaluate this to ensure that it aligns well with our school grades.

Word-length-based measures

Below, I overview the readability measures that focus on word length. Like the syllable-based measures discussed above, we selected four measures for this section.

Automated Readability Index (ARI)

The ARI gives a score that matches a U.S. school grade level, so a score of 6 means a Grade 6 learner should be able to understand it. It uses two main things. One, the ARI looks at how many letters are in each word. Longer words usually mean the text is harder to read. Two, it checks the average number of words in each sentence. Longer sentences can be harder to follow. We proposed the following formula for Sesotho:

$$ARI_{Sesotho} = -13.66031 + 2.87106\left(\frac{\#letters}{\#words}\right) + 0.49323\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right)$$

The ARI counts (i) the average number of letters per word, and (ii) the average number of words per sentence. These numbers are used in a formula that calculates a grade level. The ARI is good because it is easy for computers to use. It does not need to check syllables—just letters and sentences—so it is fast and works well for digital texts.

Läsbarhetsindex (LIX)

Läsbarhetsindex means Readability Index in Swedish. It is a way to measure how hard a text is to read. It was first made for the Swedish language but works well in English and other languages too. It looks at two things. One, it checks how long the sentences are. Long sentences are usually harder to read. Two, it counts long words—these are words with more than 6 letters. LIX uses this formula:

$$LIX_{Sesotho} = 0.46038 + 1.14736\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 0.60841\left(\frac{\#long-words}{\#words} * 100\right)$$

The final number gives a rough idea of how difficult the text is. LIX does not give a school grade like other formulas. Instead, it gives a score—the higher the score, the harder the text. It is quick and useful when comparing different texts.

Readability Index (RIX)

Both LIX and RIX output numerical values that are subsequently mapped to corresponding school grade levels. Importantly, fractional scores are typically disregarded to avoid misclassifications; for example, a score of 47.99 is treated as 47 rather than being rounded up,

which might otherwise shift the estimated grade level. We proposed the following formula for the RIX:

$$RIX_{Sesotho} = 0.02180 + 0.76883\left(\frac{\#long-words}{\#sentences}\right)$$

RIX is a simpler version of LIX. It only focuses on long words. It looks at two things. One, how many long words (more than 6 letters) are in the text? The occurrence of higher frequencies of longer words will result in a higher score for RIX, thus indicating harder-to-read texts. This is the simplest and fastest to compute, even manually, of the measures we developed for Sesotho. It is a good tool when you just want a quick idea of how challenging a text is, especially when checking lots of texts.

Coleman-Liau Index (CLI)

The Coleman-Liau Index is another tool that helps us tell how easy or hard a piece of writing is to read. So, the focus is not on the understanding aspect of reading here. It focuses on two main things. One, the length of the words. It counts how many letters are in the words. Longer words usually have more letters, which can make the text harder to read. Two, just like other readability tools, it also checks the average sentence length—how many words are in each sentence, on average.

$$DCI_{Sesotho} = 4.66547 + 0.14199\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 0.03264\left(\frac{\#difficult-words}{\#words} * 100\right)$$

Instead of counting syllables, the Coleman-Liau Index counts (i) the number of letters per 100 words, and (ii) the number of sentences per 100 words. These two numbers are put into a formula that gives a score. The score shows the grade level needed to understand the text. According to the original developers of the measure in English, each sample should end with a full sentence. So, some samples might have a few more or a few fewer than 100 words.

Word-list-based measure

Unlike the syllable-based and the word-length-based measures, we selected only one wordlist-based measure for Sesotho. Our Dale-Chall index uses the following formula:

$$DCI_{Sesotho} = 4.66547 + 0.14199\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 0.03264\left(\frac{\#difficult-words}{\#words} * 100\right)$$

The Dale-Chall Index works by answering two main questions. One, how many words are difficult? There is a special list of about 3,000 common words that most people in Grade 4 and above should know, and if a word is not on that list, it is counted as a difficult word. Two, how long are the sentences? Long sentences are usually harder to read, so the index also looks at the average sentence length (how many words are in a sentence, on average).

The index uses a formula that combines the percentage of difficult words in the text and the

average sentence length. Then, it gives a score that matches a school grade level. For example, a lower score means the text is easier to read (maybe Grade 5 or 6), and a higher score means it is harder to read (maybe Grade 11 or 12).

Example implementation

Table~\ref{tab:2.4 example use} illustrates the application of selected readability formulas to a short English text that was machine-translated from Sesotho. The results include the output of seven traditional readability formulas, alongside two surface-level statistics: average sentence length (ASL) and average word length (AWL).

The findings reveal variability across the readability scores, indicating that different formulas yield divergent assessments of text difficulty. This inconsistency supports the use of all nine traditional readability measures discussed in this thesis, particularly for triangulation and cross-validation in multilingual or translated texts.

GOOD WAYS TO MAKE CUSTOMERS HAPPY

Experts say that treating customers well is not difficult, it just requires the store owner to know different ways to make them happy. It is important to make sure that you know the names of customers who buy from your store regularly. When they arrive at the store, greet them with their names or surnames. This makes them proud and realize that you care about them. Remember that customers are not all the same. Some will be angry and burning with flames. When you talk to such a customer, don't get angry with him. Be humble and talk to him in a cool spirit. Learn to listen to your customers. If you practice listening to them, you will be able to meet their needs. Another important thing is to accept their complaints regardless of what they are complaining about. If you do this, tomorrow they will keep coming back to your shop. Ask customers what goods or products they would like to have in your store. Maybe if you can get it for them, that can save them time and money. Be available when customers need you. Don't hide and disappear from the office. Even if the customer has left a message saying call him, call him. Never make promises to customers that you cannot fulfill. If you told the customer to come on Friday to get his goods, do so.

Metrics	ASL	AWL	FRE	FKGL	DCI	CLI	GFI	SMOG	ARI
Readability	12.32	4.32	79.00	5.30	6.95	7.24	9.20	9.68	5.08

Hoba ntwana e ye ka theko, Seabata o ile a tsamaya, a ya ha hae, a ntse a rohakana. Mohatsa Sefatsa o ile a kgothaletsa monna hore a yotlaleha sepoleseng. Empa Sefatsa o ile a eba lesisitheho ka mabaka ana a mabedi: La pele, o ne a batla ho ruta motubi wa hae botho ka ntle ho thuso ya sepolesa. La bobedi ke hore sepetlele ho ne ho se ho tla kwalwa. Yaba Sefatsa o a itlhatswa, o itlosa madi; mosadi o nka lehare a mmeolela leqeba le hodima hlooho. A apara hempe e tshweu, e hlwekileng; a itereka, a tsamaya, a ya sepetlele moo a neng a sebetsa teng.

Syllables

$$FKGL_{Sesotho} = -14.08905 + 0.43405\left(\frac{\#words}{\#sentences}\right) + 5.86314\left(\frac{\#syllables}{\#words}\right)$$

$$\begin{aligned} FKGL &= -14.08905 + 0.43405(112/6) + 5.86314(220/112) \\ &= -14.08905 + 8.103 + 11.515 \\ &\approx \mathbf{5.5} \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} FRE &= 209.3286 - 1.7930(112/6) - 46.6548(220/112) \\ &= 209.3286 - 33.468 - 91.659 \\ &= \mathbf{84,22} \text{ (grade 6)} \end{aligned}$$

Ho ba n twa e na e ye ka the ko, Se a ba ta o i le a tsa ma ya, a ya ha hae, a n tse a ro ha ka na. Mo ha tsa Se fa tsa o ile a kgo tha le tsa mo n na ho re a yo tla le ha se po le se ng. E m pa Se fa tsa o i le a e ba le si si the ho ka ma ba ka a na a ma be di: La pe le, o ne a ba tla ho ru ta mo tu bi wa ha e bo tho ka n tle ho thu so ya se po le sa. La bo be di ke ho re se pe tle le ho ne ho se ho tla kwa lwa. Ya ba Se fa tsa o a i tlha tswa, o i tlo sa ma di; mo sa di o n ka le ha re a m me o le la le qe ba le ho di ma hlo o ho. A a pa ra he m pe e tshwe u, e hlwe ki le ng; a i te re ka, a tsa ma ya, a ya se pe tle le mo o a ne ng a se be tsa te ng.

Polysyllables

Ho ba n **twa** e na e ye ka **the** ko, Se a ba ta o i le a **tsa** ma ya, a ya ha **hae**, a n **tse** a ro ha ka na. Mo ha **tsa** Se fa tsa o ile a **kgo tha** le tsa mo n na ho re a yo **tla** le ha se po le se ng. E m pa Se fa **tsa** o i le a e ba le si si **the** ho ka ma ba ka a na a ma be di: La pe le, o ne a ba **tla** ho ru ta mo tu bi wa ha e bo **tho** ka n **tle** ho **thu** so ya se po le sa. La bo be di ke ho re se pe **tle** le ho ne ho se ho **tla kwa lwa**. Ya ba Se fa **tsa** o a i **tlha tswa**, o i tlo sa ma di; mo sa di o n ka le ha re a m me o le la le qe ba le ho di ma **hlo** o ho. A a pa ra he m pe e **tshwe** u, e **hlwe** ki le ng; a i te re ka, a **tsa** ma ya, a ya se pe **tle** le mo o a ne ng a se be **tsa** te ng.

Polysyllabic

$$\begin{aligned} GF I &= -1.77916 + 0.40861((112/6) + 30.9982(33/112)) \\ &= -1.77916 + 0.40861(18.6667 + 9.127) \\ &= -1.77916 + 11.363 \\ &\approx \mathbf{9.58} \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{SMOG} &= 0.28788 + 0.68741(\text{sqrt}(33 * (30/6))) \\
 &= 0.28788 + 0.68741 * 12.845 \\
 &= \mathbf{9.12}
 \end{aligned}$$

Hoba ntwana ena e ye ka theko, Seabata o ile a tsamaya, a ya ha hae, a ntse a rohakana. Mohatsa Sefatsa o ile a kgothaletsa monna hore a yo tlaleha sepoleseng. Empa Sefatsa o ile a eba lesisitheho ka mabaka ana a mabedi: La pele, o ne a batla ho ruta motubi wa hae botho ka ntle ho thuso ya sepolesa. La bobedi ke hore sepetlele ho ne ho se ho tla kwalwa. Yaba Sefatsa o a itlhatswa, o itlosa madi; mosadi o nka lehare a mmeolela leqeba le hodima hlooho. A apara hempe e tshweu, e hlwekileng; a itereka, a tsamaya, a ya sepetlele moo a neng a sebetsa teng. (33 long words)

Long words

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{RIX} &= 0.02180 + 0.76883(33/6) \\
 &= 0.02180 + 4.228565 = 4.250365 \\
 &= \mathbf{4.25}
 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{LIX} &= 0.46038 + 1.14736(112/6) + 0.60841(33/112 * 100) \\
 &= 0.46038 + 21.4144 + 17.9265 \\
 &= \mathbf{39.8013}
 \end{aligned}$$

Hoba ntwana ena e ye ka theko, Seabata o ile a tsamaya, a ya ha hae, a ntse a rohakana. Mohatsa Sefatsa o ile a kgothaletsa monna hore a yo tlaleha sepoleseng. Empa Sefatsa o ile a eba lesisitheho ka mabaka ana a mabedi: La pele, o ne a batla ho ruta motubi wa hae botho ka ntle ho thuso ya sepolesa. La bobedi ke hore sepetlele ho ne ho se ho tla kwalwa. Yaba Sefatsa o a itlhatswa, o itlosa madi; mosadi o nka lehare a mmeolela leqeba le hodima hlooho. A apara hempe e tshweu, e hlwekileng; a itereka, a tsamaya, a ya sepetlele moo a neng a sebetsa teng.

Letters

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{ARI} &= -13.66031 + 2.87106(424/112) + 0.49323(112/6) \\
 &= -13.66031 + 10.872 + 9.209 \\
 &\approx \mathbf{6.42}
 \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned}
 \text{CLI} &= -3.683470 + 0.038782(424/112 * 100) - 0.727659(6/112 * 100) \\
 &= -3.683470 + 14.679 - 3.899 \\
 &= \mathbf{7.10}
 \end{aligned}$$

Hoba ntwana e ye ka theko, Seabata o ile a tsamaya, a y
 a ha hae, a ntse a rohakana. Mohatsa Sefatsa o ile a kgoth
 aletsa monna hore a yo tlaleha sepoleseng. Empa Sefatsa o
 ile a eba lesisitheho ka mabaka ana a mabedi: La pele, o n
 e a batla ho ruta motubi wa hae botho ka ntle ho thuso ya
 sepolesa. La bobedi ke hore sepetele ho ne ho se ho tla kw
 alwa. Yaba Sefatsa o a itlhatswa, o itlosa madi; mosadi o
 nka lehare a mmeolela leqeba le hodima hlooho. A apara h
 empe e tshweu, e hlwekileng; a itereka, a tsamaya, a ya se
 petele moo a neng a sebetsa teng. (424 characters)

Summary

Two important things can be learned from the nine readability formulas discussed in this section. First, each formula has its own way of checking how easy or hard a text is to read and what school grade level it matches. These methods are important, especially when choosing how much text is needed to test them properly in Sesotho. Using samples can help with longer texts, but it may not work well for short ones—except for the SMOG formula, which has a special version for short texts.

Second, each formula focuses more on certain features of the text. These features can affect how readable a text is. For example, some formulas focus more on sentence length, others on word length or syllables. These parts might need to be changed to work better with the Sesotho language. Note that at this point, I keep this in the current Sesotho formulas. Even so, I learned that when comparing the ARI formula in English, Croatian, and Czech, different languages might need different settings.

To make the readability formulas work for Sesotho, we looked at:

- word details (how long the words are, how many there are, and the average word length),
- sentence details (how long the sentences are, how many there are, and their average length),
- syllable details (how many syllables words have and their average),
- a list of common words used in Sesotho.

Lastly, we also need to think about what kind of scores the formulas give. Some, like FRE, LIX, and RIX, do not give grade levels directly. For these, we may need to do extra work to match their scores to school grade levels.



Chapter 4:

Readability in African Language Contexts

- Challenges in Applying English-based Formulas to Sesotho
- Developing Context-Aware Readability Practices
- Current Research and Developments in South Africa

Chapter 5: Assessing Readability Practically

Manual Techniques for Estimating Readability

Teachers can use simple, manual strategies to assess the readability of a Sesotho text, especially where digital tools are unavailable.

Key indicators to consider:

- Sentence length
 - Count the number of words in a sentence.
 - Shorter sentences (10–15 words) are generally easier to understand for lower grade levels.
- Word length and familiarity
 - Look for long, rare, or compound words.
 - Aim for everyday vocabulary, especially in Foundation and Intermediate Phases.
- Paragraph structure
 - Are ideas clearly separated?
 - Does each paragraph focus on one main idea?
- Text layout and visuals
 - Is the font clear?
 - Are there headings or pictures to support understanding?

Analysing Vocabulary Load in a Sesotho Text

Understanding the vocabulary load helps teachers identify whether a text is accessible to learners at a particular grade level.

Steps to follow:

- Select a 100-word sample from the text.
- Count how many words are likely unfamiliar to learners in that grade.
- Consider:
 - Use of idiomatic expressions
 - Loanwords or archaic terms
 - Abstract vs. concrete vocabulary

Tip: If more than 10–15% of the words are unfamiliar, the text may be too difficult for the target group.

Checking Sentence Structure and Flow

Clear and logical sentence construction is crucial for readability.

What to check:

- Are sentences overly long or complex?
Break long sentences into two or more simpler ones.
- Are ideas clearly linked?
Use appropriate connectors (e.g., *hobane*, *leha ho le joalo*).
- Does the text follow a logical flow?
Ideas should build on one another, especially in narrative or expository texts.

Using Peer and Learner Feedback

Involving others in the process gives insight into how a text is received in real classrooms.

Peer Review:

- Exchange texts with a colleague.
- Discuss clarity, structure, and appropriateness for grade level.

Learner Feedback:

- Let learners read a short passage aloud or silently.
- Ask:
 - Was anything confusing?
 - Which words or sentences were hard?
 - What did they understand easily?

Benefits:

- Encourages learner agency
- Highlights classroom realities that technical measures might miss



Final Note:

No single method gives a complete picture. Combine these techniques to make informed decisions that support learner success, especially when teaching in African languages like Sesotho.

Chapter 6: Improving Text Readability

Simplify a Text Without Losing Meaning

When Maya sat down to revise her article, she felt stuck. The content was solid—research-backed, carefully argued—but something wasn’t right. Her supervisor had marked it with one blunt comment: “*Too dense. Simplify.*”

At first, Maya worried that simplifying meant *dumbing down*. But then she remembered what her writing tutor once told her: “*Clarity isn’t the enemy of intelligence.*”

So, she began.

First, Maya thought about who would read her piece. Were they familiar with technical terms? Would they be reading quickly or slowly? That helped her realise some words were too complex. She changed “utilise” to “use,” “commence” to “start,” and “endeavour” to “try.” The meaning stayed the same, but the sentences breathed easier.

Next, she tackled sentence length. One of her paragraphs had a 42-word sentence, straining like a marathon runner. She split it in two, then in three. Suddenly, her argument moved with pace and rhythm.

Voice was next. Maya noticed how often she slipped into the passive voice: “*The experiment was conducted...*” She flipped it: “*We conducted the experiment.*” Now the writing felt more alive, more accountable.

She began looking at the structure. She added subheadings, broke paragraphs into shorter chunks, and used bullet points where a list would help. The piece no longer felt like a wall of text—it invited the reader in.

Lastly, she trimmed the fat: “each and every” became “each,” and “due to the fact that” was cut down to “because.” Redundant phrases vanished. Her text lost weight but gained strength.

By the end of the day, Maya read her article aloud. It was clearer, tighter, and more engaging—without losing the original meaning. She had simplified, not diluted.

And when she submitted the new draft, her supervisor’s reply was only one word: “*Excellent.*”

Using Local Contexts to Support Comprehension

Sipho was tutoring his younger cousin, Zinzi, on a chapter about climate change. The textbook described rising sea levels and melting glaciers—concepts that felt distant and abstract to Zinzi, who lived in a small inland town in South Africa.

She frowned. “Why do I need to care about ice melting in places I’ll never see?”

Sipho paused. Then he said, “Remember last summer, when the water restrictions got worse? And the dam almost dried up?” Zinzi nodded. “That’s climate change too,” he explained. “It’s not just about polar bears—it’s about us, right here.”

That shift changed everything.

Sipho had used **local context**—something familiar and immediate—to make the concept relatable. Suddenly, Zinzi understood not just the *what*, but the *why*.

Teachers, writers, and communicators do this all the time when they:

- **Draw on local events** to explain global phenomena.
- **Use examples from learners' environments**, like local languages, customs, or geography.
- **Relate abstract terms to real-life situations** people know well.

By rooting information in what people already know or experience, comprehension becomes easier—and deeper. As Sipho realised that day, when ideas are brought closer to home, they're more likely to stay.

Visual Aids and Layout in Text Design

Naledi was preparing a community health pamphlet. She had all the facts: statistics on vaccination rates, prevention tips, and clinic hours. But when she showed a draft to her colleague Thabo, he flipped through it silently, then said, “It’s solid—but no one’s going to read this.”

Naledi blinked. “Why not?”

“It looks like a wall of words,” he said, tapping the page. “People’s eyes will slide right off.”

So they sat together to rethink the **layout**.

First, they broke the information into **sections**, each with a clear heading: *What You Need to Know*, *When to Get Vaccinated*, *Where to Go*. They added **bulleted lists** for easy scanning and used **bold text** to highlight key points like *free services* and *emergency numbers*.

Next, they brought in **visual aids**:

- A simple diagram showing the vaccine timeline.
- A photo of a smiling nurse at the local clinic.
- Icons for “safe,” “free,” and “nearby” services.

Each image served a purpose—it wasn’t just decoration. The visuals helped people *see* the message, not just read it.

When the final pamphlet was printed, Naledi handed it to a local shopkeeper. He glanced at it and smiled, “Ah! This is clear. I’ll put it on the counter.”

That was the power of thoughtful **text design**: good layout and meaningful visuals turned dry information into something people could use—at a glance, on the go, and in their lives.

Collaborating with Learners in Text Creation

Lerato was teaching a group of Grade 9 learners about environmental conservation. She had planned to give them a ready-made booklet to summarise the topic, but during the first lesson, she noticed something: the learners weren't connecting. They read the material, answered questions—but their responses were flat, rehearsed.

After class, one learner stayed behind. “Miss,” he said, “Why don’t we make our *own* booklet? We know what’s happening here better than the examples in this one.”

That moment sparked a shift.

The next week, Lerato split the class into small groups. One wrote about illegal dumping near the taxi rank. Another created a comic strip showing how litter affects local animals. A third group interviewed elders about how the river had changed over the years.

Lerato guided them, helping with structure, language, and facts—but the ideas and words were theirs.

By the end of the term, they had co-created a powerful, locally grounded booklet. It was filled with their voices, their pictures, and their realities. When they shared it with another class, they stood a little taller.

Through this collaborative text creation, the learners were not just consuming knowledge—they were shaping it. They engaged more deeply, thought more critically, and saw themselves as active participants in learning.

For Lerato, it was clear: when learners help make the text, they do not just understand it better—they own it.

Summary

Effective Sesotho language teaching in South African primary and secondary schools can be significantly strengthened through simplified texts, local relevance, visual design, and active learner collaboration.

Firstly, simplifying Sesotho texts—by using plain language, shorter sentences, and active voice—makes learning more accessible without sacrificing meaning. This is especially helpful for learners who may find overly formal or complex texts intimidating.

Secondly, grounding reading materials in local, familiar contexts enhances relevance and comprehension. Today’s learners are digital natives, often fluent in multilingual social media slang that blends Sesotho, English, Afrikaans, and township varieties. Incorporating examples from their digital lives—such as WhatsApp conversations, TikTok captions, or memes—can bridge the gap between school language and real-world expression. This approach helps learners see Sesotho as dynamic and adaptable, not confined to rigid classroom norms.

Thirdly, effective text design—including clear layout, bullet points, and culturally appropriate visuals—supports understanding, especially for visual learners and younger children. Visual aids also help to scaffold meaning for learners who may still be developing fluency.

Lastly, involving learners in creating their own Sesotho texts—through storytelling, dialogues, or media-based projects—builds ownership and deepens engagement. Learners become not just readers but authors of language, linking school-based learning with their lived experiences.

Together, these strategies help create inclusive, relevant, and empowering learning environments for Sesotho language development in the 21st century.

Post Section Activity

If you are able to, pair up with your colleagues and complete the activity below.

Individually, participants reflect and jot down responses to the following questions:

1. Have you ever simplified a Sesotho text for your learners? What did you change?
2. What local, digital, or cultural references do your learners use when they communicate (e.g., social media slang, memes, hashtags)?
3. How could visuals (e.g., icons, emojis, infographics) support understanding in a Sesotho lesson?
4. Have you ever involved learners in creating their own texts? What was the result?

Participants pair up and share their reflections. Each pair should:

- Identify one challenge they've both faced in making Sesotho texts readable.
- Discuss one strategy they've used (or could use) to include learners' digital or multilingual realities in the classroom.
- Choose one visual or design element they think could enhance a Sesotho lesson.

Pairs report back to the larger group. The facilitator captures key insights on a whiteboard or shared digital document under three headings:

- Challenges in teaching readable, relevant Sesotho texts
- Innovative strategies inspired by learners' real-world language use
- Visual tools that aid comprehension

Chapter 7: **Hands-On Workshop Activities**

In this section, we will practice simplifying texts for ease of readability.

Text A

Ka letsatsi le hlhlamang, Ngwepepe a tsoha ka dialla a leba ka morao ho motse. A hlola moo ho fihlela tsatsi le rapama mme yare ha le qala ho diketsa nko mobung le yena a be a kena hae. Ha a fihla, a bolella morena hore a batle banna ba bahlano e be yena wa botshelela mme e re ka seroko se seholo, ba tswe le mofumahadi ba lebe mahaheng a ka mora motse le yena. A ree yena ba tla mo fumana a se a ba emetse ka ntle ho motse, a shebane le tseo a tla beng a shebane le tsona.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)

Text B

Ka hora tsa baloi morena a tswa le mofumahadi Dibabatso hammoho le banna ba badilweng ke ngaka, ba y a moo ho itsweng ba ye teng. Ba tsamaya ba thotse tu! Ho se ya buisang e mong, mofumahadi ba mo kentse hare. Yare ha ba fihla ka ntle ho motse, ke hore moo matlo a fellang teng, ba bona motho a re thoso! Hara lefifi a etla ho bona. Ngwepepe a itlhoma pele ho bona mme ba mo sala morao. A tsamaya a tswapela mona le mane, a ba tlama hore ba be ba tsamaye ba kolokile ka baka la tsela bobe. Yare ha ba fihla lehaheng leo a le kgethileng, a re banna ba bahlano ba sale ka ntle , ba furalle lehaha ba shebe moo ba neng ba etswa.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)

Text C

Ka mora kgwedi tse pedi a ntse a enwa pitsa tseo tsa Ngwepepe, mofumahadi Dibabatso a tsebisa morena Monaheng hore o ithwetse. Thabo ya Monaheng ya eba e kgaphatsehang ruri ha a utlwa mantswe ao a etswa molomong wa thatohatsi ya hae. Yare ha mmila o ntse o puta, dibeke le dikgwedi di ntse di feta, batho ba bang le bona ba iponela ka a bona mahlo hore efela mofumahadi a ithwetse.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

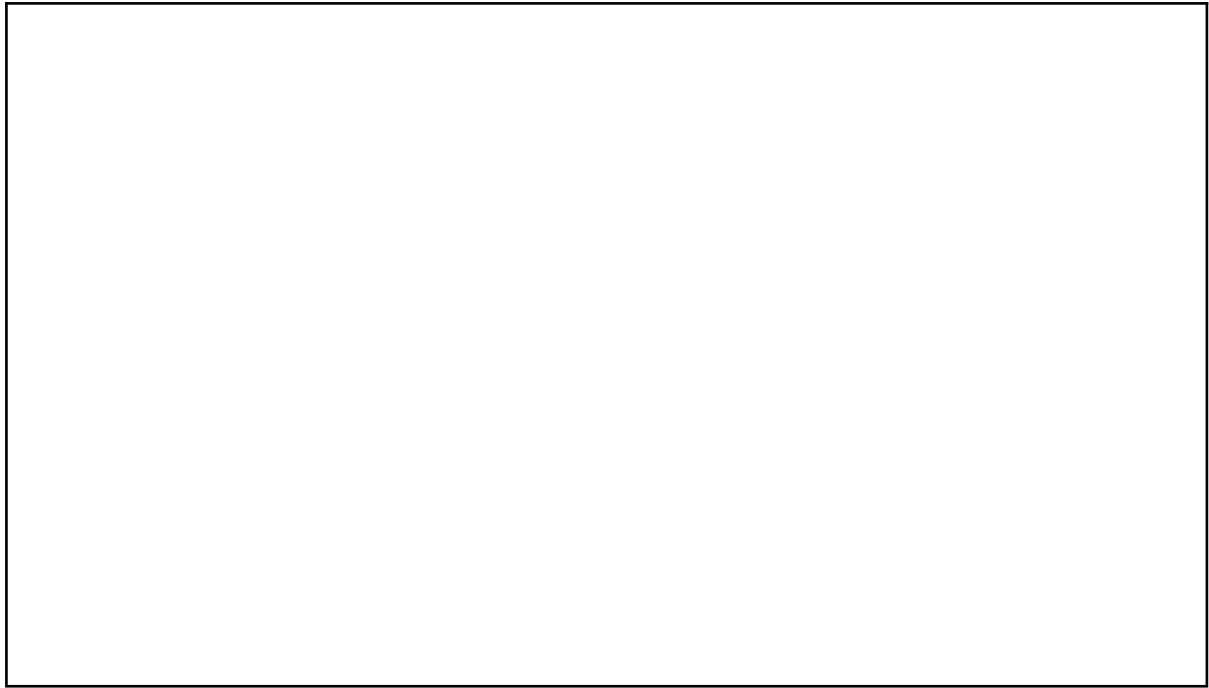
- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)



Text D

Ha motho o tloha Maseru o ya Butha-Buthe ka mmila o moholo o kopanyang dikampo tsa Lesotho ka mabalane, naha ya Lesotho e senoleha bonyenyane. Ka letsohong le letshehadi ho wena e se e le le leng la mahlahana a Senqu, Mohokare; noka e entseng moedi pakeng tsa Lesotho le naha ya Foreisetata. Bakeng tse ding, hona ha o ntse o tsamaya ka mmila, naha ya Foreisetata ke sebakana sa mmetsalejwe feela ho tloha ho wena. Ka letsohong le letona mahlo a hao a wela mekoloko ya Maloti. Ho tloha moleng ho ya moo mekoloko e qalehang teng e ka ba feela leeto la letsatsi ka pere. Ere kaha sebaka sa Maloti ha se dumellane le metse ya ditsetle, sebakeng sena se pakeng tsa noka ya Mohokare le maotong a maloti ke hona feela moo ho ka lebellwang metse e meholo.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)

Text E

Mmila o tatamala jwalo ho tloha Maseru. O fihla o mula kampo ya Teyateyaneng ka lehare. O thulamela ho haba Phuthiatsana. Mona le mane o ntse o etsa matsutlatsutla a ona a tsamayang a etsa dilaselase tseo bakeng tse ding motho o ka bang wa tiisa hore o dilemo o sa sebetswe. O re o tloha o ropohe o bile o thinya hoo makoloi a ka nnang a etsa dikotsi ha baqhobi ba se sedi. Kampo ya Hlotse le yona mmila o e mamola ka lehare . Hoba o tswe ka hara motse wa kampo, o tshwara thota. Ka ho le letona ke dikolo tsa thoteng, ha ka ho le letshehadi e le lekote la dipere. Ke moo ka letsatsi la Moshweshwe ho tshwarwang peiso e kgolo mona Leribe. O tatamala jwalo ho ya feta letsheng la Mmadinakana o nto tshwara moepa. O dikele, o hoballe jwalo ho ya feta Mohobollo. O tla tsamaya o tswa makgolo o be o yo re Butha-Buthe kutu.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

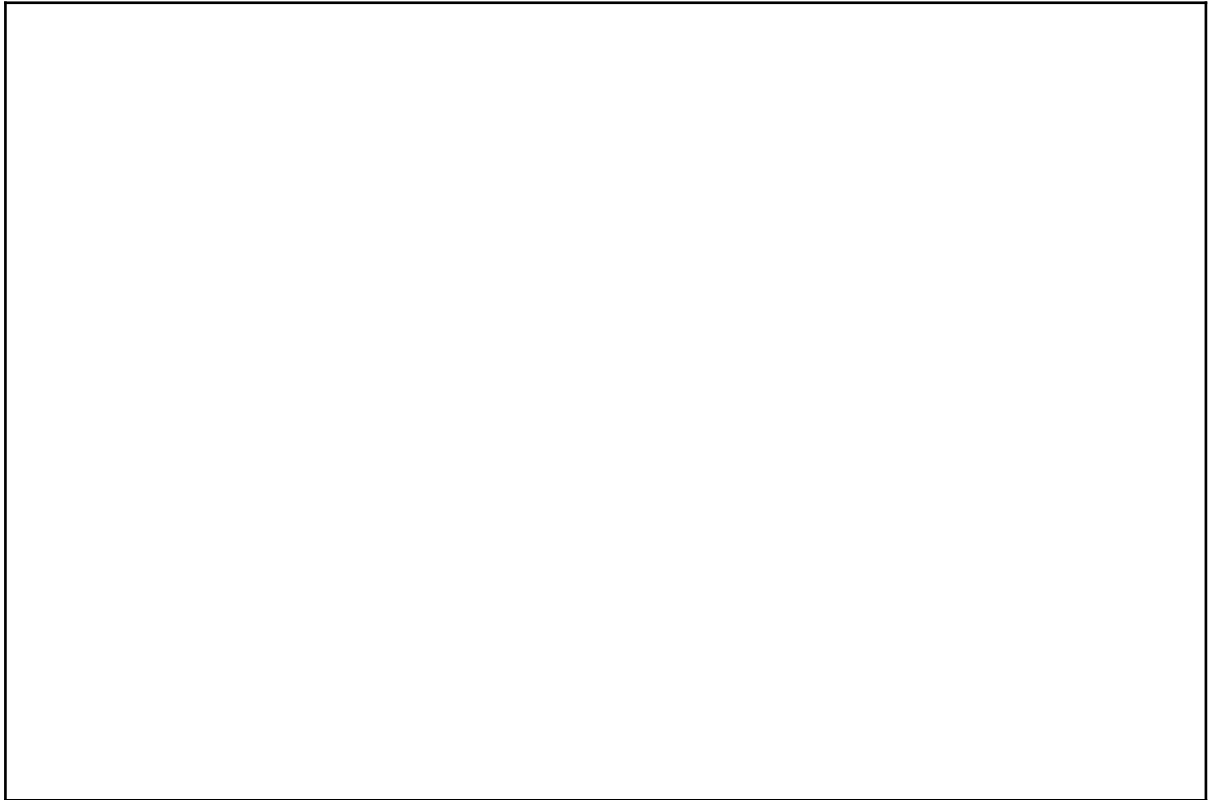
- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners

- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)



Text F

Re qetile matsatsi le masiu a mabedi a boima moo lefifing la ntlwanatshwana, ntle le dijo kapa metsi. Le hore masiu a sele re ne re pakelwa feela ke ho lla ha mekoko le merusu ya motsheare. Ha e le kganya yona re ne re sa e tsebe hohang.

Re ne re lapile, mme re nyorilwe haholo. Re ne re tshedisana mme re tiisetsana hore ho molemo haholo ho shwela naha ya heno, ho e na le hore o fetohe lehlabaphiyo le tla qetella le shwele empa le shweletse baditjhaba. Lehlabaphiyo le tla tlisetsa baena le dikgaitsemi sekgobo se sa t lo hlakoha le ka mohla. Ra hla ra ikemisetsa ho shwa ha ho hloka hla, etswe le motswalle wa rona Malefane a ne a se a re etelletse pele.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

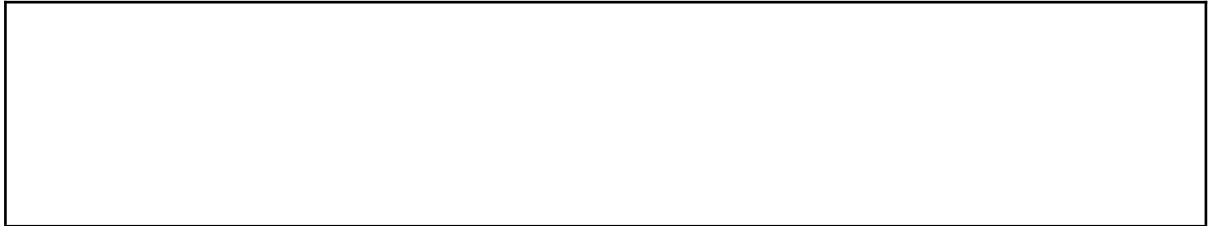
- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?



- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

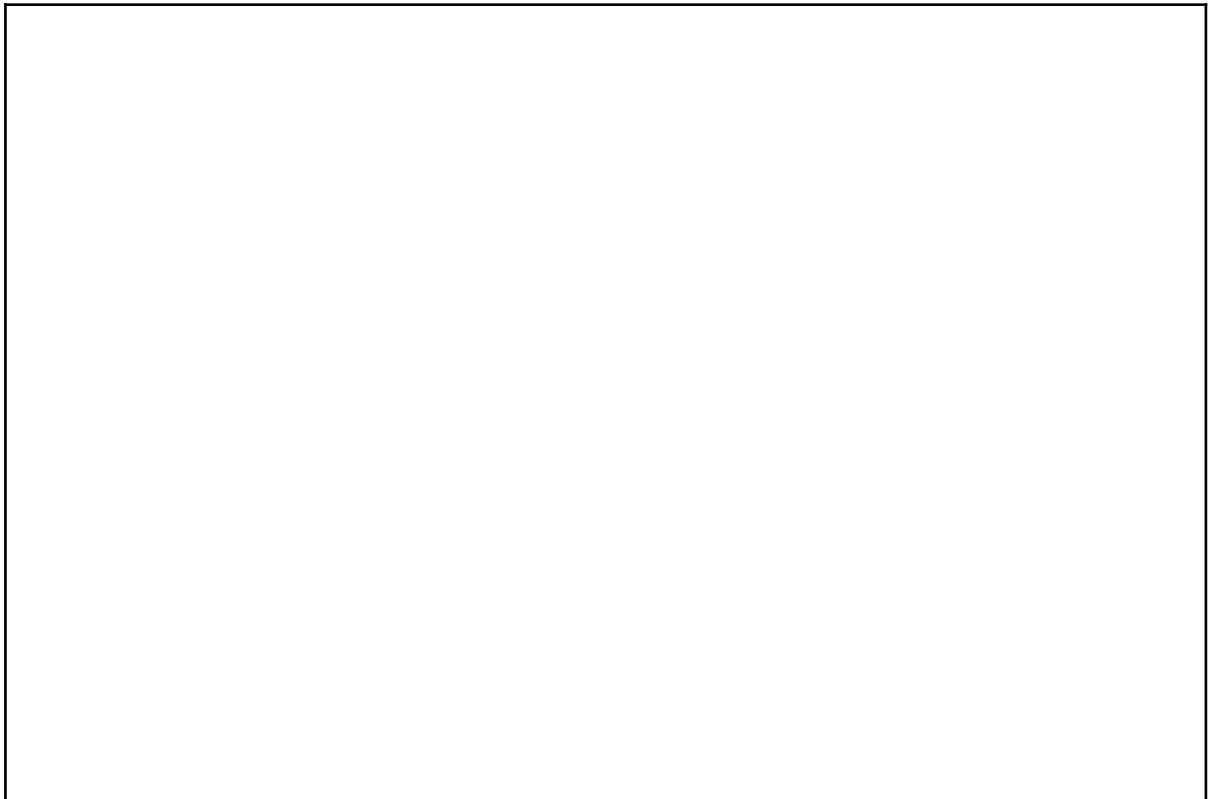


- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.



Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)



Text G

Re ne re utlwa bohloko haholo ha re hopola eo motswalle wa rona ya shwetseng mahlong a rona a se na molato ho babolai ba hae. Ra itshedisa ka mantswe a Sesotho a reng ngwana e motona ke kabelwamanong, lebitla la ha e ke mohodu wa phiri le lekanyane. E, le kajeno ke ntse ke dumela hore ngwana e motona ke pelesa ya mathata a lefatshe. Le ha e le mona ke phetse ke ntse ke rialo. Ho sa le jwalo, ka utlwa diqi mme lemati la buleha. Ha kena Sephankga le Molelle ba hatela hodimo. Ha bua Molelle: “Banna, ha ke lakatse ho le patella hore le tsietsing e kgolo. Le itjheketse lebitla ka ho halefisa e moholo. Ho le lokelang hona jwale ke lefu, lefu feela. Lefu!” Bobedi ra oma ka dihlooho e le bopaki le sesupo sa hore re fela re utlwisisa hantle hore re halefisitse “e moholo”, le hore re a elellwa hore re se re re le bafu, ha ho potang.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

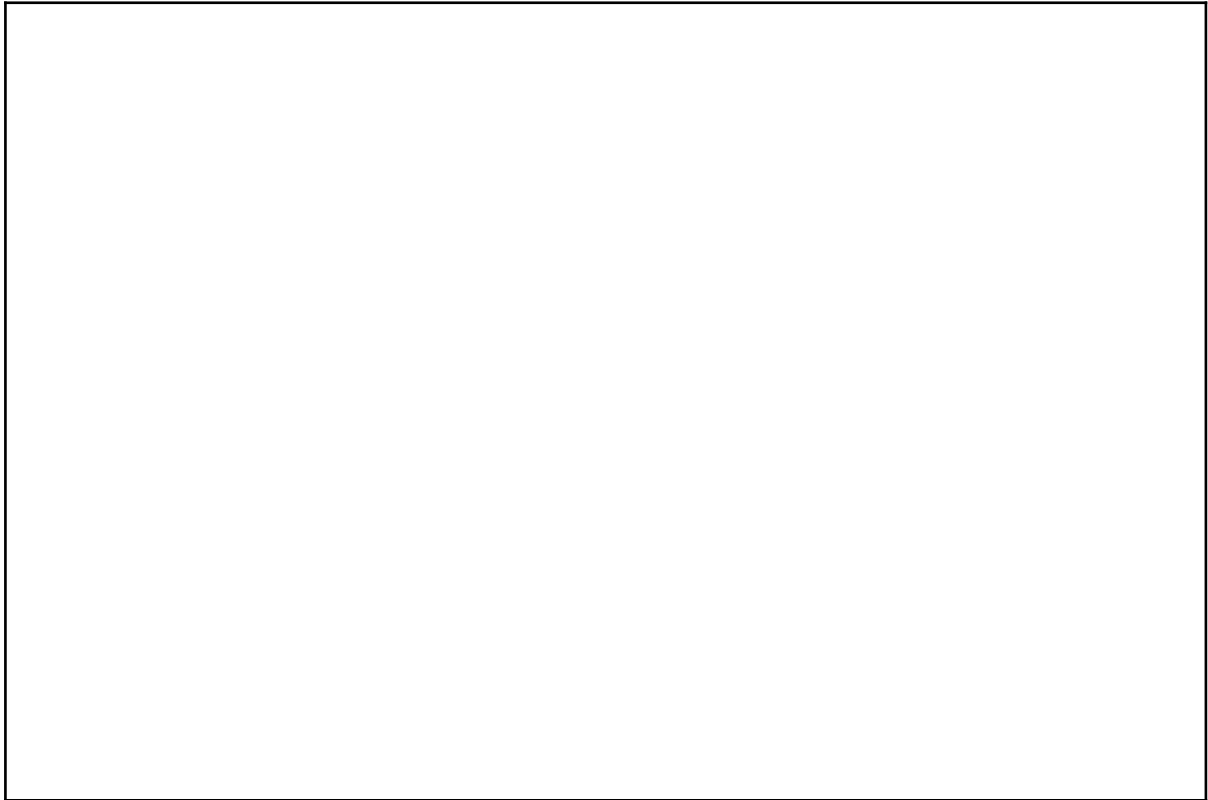
- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners

- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)



Text H

Monghadi Motebang o ne a ena le baradi ba babedi le moshanyana, hantlentle moshanyana yena e ne e le ngwana wa ho fela. Baradi bana ba hae e ne e le dithatohatsi tse kgolo tsa monghadi ho ena le enwa mora eo mmae a neng a mo rata ho shwa. Taba ena e batla e makatsa ho ba neng ba e bona le ho e utlwela. Ho monghadi Motebang e ne e sa tshose le ho makatsa hobane yena o ne a bona leruo le monono ka baradi ba hae. 'E, mohlang ba nyalwang ke sa tla fumana dikgomo e seng manamane,' ke yena eo ha a bua ho mofumahadi. Ka letsatsi lena la Sontaha, esale ka matjeke, monghadi Motebang a tsoha a jele mabifi. Tjhe, ena e ne e se ntho e sa makatseng hobane e ne e se e le tlwaelo ya hae ho ba jwalo.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?



- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)

Text I

Monghadi a kena ka phaposing eo baradi ba hae ba robetseng ka ho yona. 'Le fihlile neng maobane bosiu?' A so qete le ho bua baradi ba rutloloha diphateng tsa bona hobane ba bone kubu matsohong a ntata bona. 'Ntate re tswile ka mora nako e neng e balletswe mminong ka baka la bongata ba dikhwaere.' Ho bua Dirontsho a se a kgumame ka pela ntatae. Ha monghadi Motebang a tadima Dineo, yena le ho bua a sa bue a bebenya melomo feela, lentswe le hana ho tswa. Dineo a sala a eme tlekelele a sa tsebe seo a ka se etsang.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)

Text J

Enwa monna o ne a ithata, a hlwekile. Hohle mooa tsamayang le metswalle ya hae, o ne a sa bue habedi le monna e be o se a bitswa fatshe. Feela taba e makatsang ke hore o ne a ratwa haholo hoo metswalle ya hae e neng e mo lata hae. Ha ho qoqwa mona ka mathata le botlokotsebe ba bana ba morao tjena, o ne a feroha dibete ha monna e mong a ka re,' Banna, baka ba ntlhotse.' Monghadi Motebang e be o tla mo tswerelela mahlo a re,'Thupa e otlollwa e sa le metsi.' A ikutlwe eka a ka tshwara monna eo ka matsoho.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.



Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)



Text K

Ka bosiu bo bong Molelle, ka ha e ne le yena mora, a fihla e se e le kgale mmae a mmatla. Monghadi Motebang eitse ha a mmona a re feela,' Ena ke pholo,ke lekanyane ntho ya bosiu, ke yena moshanyana wa sebele.' Mmae taba ena e ne e mo kudisa haholo a sa e rate. Monghadi Motebang o ne a sebetsa mosebetsi o kgabane wa diofisi tsa mmuso. E se e le dilemo a sebetsa moo mme a ratwa haholo. Ka tsatsi le leng a re o tadima matsatsi a kgwedi a ya a hopola hore ke beke e setseng Dirontsho a be a le mashome a mabedi a motso o mong a dilemo. A ipolella hore o tla etsa mokete wa semetletsahadi a o etsetsa morwetsana eo.

Reflect and answer the following questions in writing:

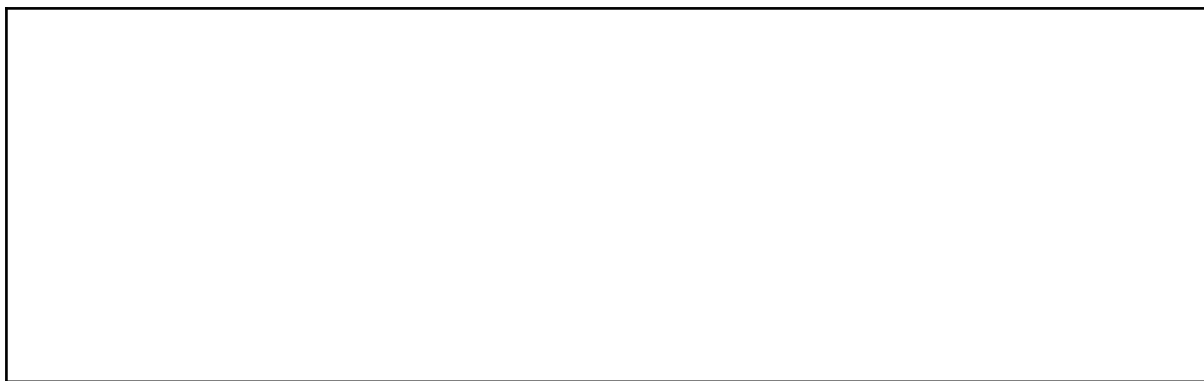
- Which words or phrases might be difficult for learners to understand?

- What local or digital references (such as social media slang, community events, or everyday experiences) could you add to make the text more relatable to your learners?

- What visual aids or formatting (like headings, bullet points, or symbols) would help learners better understand this text? Describe or sketch your ideas.

Using your answers, create a revised version of the text that:

- Uses simpler language and shorter sentences
- Includes at least one local or digital context element relevant to learners
- Suggests visual/layout features to support comprehension (you can annotate or describe these alongside the text)





Chapter 9:

Reimagining Readability in Sesotho Language Education

This handbook set out to provide practical strategies for improving the readability of Sesotho texts used in primary and secondary schools across South Africa. At its core, the aim has been to promote more inclusive, accessible, and learner-responsive literacy practices that reflect the realities of multilingual classrooms, digital environments, and culturally diverse communities. Throughout the sections, the focus has remained on the need to move beyond a narrow or technical view of "readability" and instead to approach it as a relational, contextual, and creative process.

We began by exploring what it means to simplify a text without losing meaning. This goes beyond shortening words or reducing vocabulary load; it involves making deliberate linguistic and pedagogical choices that ensure texts remain meaningful and engaging for learners with varying levels of proficiency. Simplification must preserve the richness of the Sesotho language while making it accessible. Importantly, simplification does not mean dilution—it means crafting with care.

Next, the handbook introduced **narrative structure** as a powerful tool for enhancing comprehension. Stories are not only central to Basotho oral tradition but also essential to how humans understand and remember information. A narrative frame offers learners emotional entry points into texts, encourages inferencing, and supports long-term retention. By using storytelling techniques, teachers can scaffold abstract or academic content in ways that feel familiar and compelling to learners.

We also addressed the importance of **local contexts**, recognising that learners bring rich cultural knowledge, daily experiences, and linguistic repertoires into the classroom. In an era shaped by digital communication and widespread social media use, many learners—particularly digital and social media natives—operate fluidly across multiple languages, dialects, and registers. Their informal multilingualism, often expressed through memes, slang, hashtags, and voice notes, is not a threat to academic literacy but a resource to be harnessed. When texts acknowledge these realities—by using local names, digital references, or multilingual examples—they become more relatable, more readable, and more meaningful.

In addition, **visual design and layout** were explored as crucial yet often overlooked elements in text comprehension. Well-structured texts that make use of headings, bullet points, spacing, images, and icons can significantly reduce the cognitive load for learners. Visual scaffolding supports all readers but is especially vital for struggling readers, second-language learners, and those with diverse learning needs. In multilingual classrooms, design choices can determine whether a learner engages with or withdraws from a text.

One of the most transformative strategies highlighted was **collaborating with learners in the creation of texts**. This positions learners not just as recipients of knowledge but as active co-authors in the classroom. When learners are invited to write, edit, translate, or redesign texts, they build both literacy skills and a sense of ownership. This collaborative approach

also allows teachers to better understand learner perspectives, including their preferred communication styles, vocabulary, and interests.

The final section of the handbook presented a set of **individual activities based on short texts**, designed to put theory into practice. These activities support educators in applying principles of simplification, contextualisation, visual design, and learner collaboration to actual Sesotho texts. These exercises are not only for pre-service teacher training but can also be adapted for professional development workshops, curriculum design teams, and classroom-based action research.

Moving Forward: A Call to Practice

The challenge of improving Sesotho readability is part of a broader challenge of decolonising language education in South Africa. Readability is not a neutral or purely linguistic concept—it is political, pedagogical, and ethical. When a learner struggles to access a text, the problem often lies not with the learner, but with the assumptions embedded in the text itself: assumptions about prior knowledge, cultural references, or linguistic ability. This handbook invites educators to question those assumptions and to imagine new possibilities.

Ultimately, improving Sesotho readability is about **recognising learners as whole people**—people who think, feel, speak multiple languages, and navigate complex social worlds. It is about crafting materials that meet learners where they are, without compromising on intellectual or cultural depth. And it is about giving learners the tools to succeed in academic contexts while valuing the linguistic and cultural capital they already possess.

This work is ongoing. Every classroom, every learner, every text presents new challenges and opportunities. But with conscious effort, collaborative practices, and a learner-centred mindset, we can build a generation of readers and writers who engage with Sesotho not as a difficult subject to master, but as a living language that reflects who they are and who they are becoming.
